Chapter 2
Cloudy Waters

Struggle for the Throne

On 23 September 1925, Maharaja Pratap Singh passed away.[1] Although Hari Singh was in line to succeed the late king, two issues gained currency even as the Maharaja's body lay awaiting its last rites. The state was governed by the Council of State since 1920 and the Resident, Sir John Wood, had to officially recognise Hari Singh as the new Maharaja.[2] But Wood was away on tour in Hunza and his first assistant, knowing Raja Jagat Dev Singh's claim to the throne, decided to directly communicate to Hari Singh that the Government of India recognised him as the new Maharaja. Despite this act of apparent goodwill, far from experiencing a smooth succession, Hari Singh was shocked when the Viceroy's condolence telegram addressed him as Raja Hari Singh instead of Maharaja. This, he feared, put him in the same status as the late Maharaja's adopted son Raja Jagat Dev Singh.

The problem did not end there. According to the rules of succession of a natural heir in the direct line, a prince succeeded his demised father as a matter of course and his succession was recognised by an exchange of formal letters or *kharita*s between the new ruler and the Viceroy of India.[3] The Viceroy had to first recognise and accept the succession of the new ruler and only after that, could the exchange of *kharitas* take place. Hari Singh's succession was peculiar because he was not the late Maharaja's son